

1.1 The Indian PC Landscape

Officially, the percentage of Indians paying money for the software they use is about 25 per cent (www.thehindubusinessline.com/2006/03/30/stories/2006033003470400.htm). It is “normal” for Indians to pay for the PC hardware and expect it to come with all the required software. Either deliberately or due to ignorance, PC buyers pirate software and are for the most part unaware of the illegal nature of their actions.

While many argue that the price of licensed software is the main reason for piracy in India, this excuse cannot be used as a fig leaf by any self-respecting Indian. There are two ways to redeem ourselves: either pay for the software on the PC—and this could total up to almost the cost of the hardware—or turn to Open Source Software (OSS).

1.1.1 Why Is OSS Of Special Importance To India?

With a PC penetration of 1.4 per cent (www.zdnetindia.com/news/national/stories/366,121093.html), considering our population, thou-

Some Common Terms

Paid Software: Software that is bought for a fee

Free Software: Software that is available free of cost—also called freeware.

Source Code: The human readable text that is written in the syntax of the programming language and consists of the logic and commands of the program.

Compiler: A program that prepares a source code and converts it into machine-readable form.

Binary/Executable: This is created from the source code by compiling it. In this form, the program cannot be read by humans.

Open Source: Software whose source code is available

Closed Source: Software whose source code is not available

Proprietary Software: This would obviously mean a software that has a proprietor. But the term is usually used for paid, closed-source software. We shall continue in the same vein. The opposite would be free open source software or FOSS.

Commercial Software: Commercial Software, for the purpose of this chapter as well as logically, means software used in commercial enterprises. But the term is also used for closed source, paid software. Non-commercial software usually applies to software used for not-for-profit purposes and personal use.

Vendor: For brevity, vendor refers to the software creator/owner and seller.